of access to private property, it is a danger that the government may not impose absent a compelling interest.

C

The Commission has emphasized that appellant's customers own the "extra space" in the billing envelopes. App. to Juris. Statement A–64 to A–66. According to appellees, it follows that appellant cannot have a constitutionally protected interest in restricting access to the envelopes. This argument misperceives both the relevant property rights and the nature of the State's First Amendment violation.[14]

The Commission expressly declined to hold that under California law appellant's customers own the entire billing envelopes and everything contained therein. *Id.*, at A–2 to A–3. It decided only that the ratepayers own the "extra space" in the envelope, defined as that space left over after including the bill and required notices, up to a weight of one ounce. *Ibid.* The envelopes themselves, the bills, and *Progress* all remain appellant's property. The Commission's access order thus clearly requires appellant to use *its* property as a vehicle for spreading a message with which it disagrees. In *Wooley* v. *Maynard*, we held that New Hampshire could not require two citizens to display a slogan on their license plates and thereby "use their private property as a 'mobile billboard' for the State's ideological message." 430 U. S., at 715. The "private property" that was used to spread the unwelcome message was the automobile, not the license plates. Similarly, the Commission's order requires appellant to use its property—the billing envelopes—to dis-

[14] Appellees also argue that appellant's status as a regulated utility company lessens its right to be free from state regulation that burdens its speech. We have previously rejected this argument. *Consolidated Edison Co.* v. *Public Service Comm'n of N. Y.*, 447 U. S., at 534, n. 1 ("Consolidated Edison's position as a regulated monopoly does not decrease the informative value of its opinions on critical public matters"). See also *Central Hudson Gas & Electric Corp.* v. *Public Service Comm'n of N. Y.*, 447 U. S. 557, 566–568 (1980).